

Academic debate on

How ‘anchored’ and ‘transient’ identities are negotiated in online environments. In your answer, integrate social network theory (e.g., Wellman, Giddens) and discuss how online platforms reshape the performance, visibility, and stability of identity.

1. Introduction

In the last three decades, the rapid expansion of digital technologies has fundamentally reshaped how individuals construct, perform, and communicate identity. It is essential to know the tension between anchored identities (stable, historically rooted) and transient identities (fluid, performative, mutable). Identity performance within the wider social shifts described by theorists such as Giddens, Bauman, and Wellman. How individuals navigate anchored and transient identities within digital spaces, integrating social network theory and Merchant's concepts of performance, audience, and multimodality.

Identity has become a central focus in studies of digital culture because online communication creates new ways for people to express and perform who they are. As people use the Internet to interact across diverse and disseminated networks, questions emerge about how these technologies reshape social identity. Both adult and children's online practices show that identity performance is deeply woven into digital communication. Because, first, that new communication tools enable new forms of identity play, and second, that broader social and economic changes in modern society require people to create new kinds of social networks and identities.

2. Digital identity, challenges and opportunities

A. The identity threat discourse: A discourse influenced by moral panic raises anxieties, sense of future shock in computer based communication mainly because of the latent tendency to mistrust technology by individual. Some themes of scare stories:

- Your virtual property is never secure; it can be stolen or maliciously corrupted by viruses.
- Your personal details are easy to locate, so easy that Internet criminals can steal and use your identity (your money).
- You are constantly under surveillance: where you go, what you do and what you say is always tracked.
- Your personal safety is at risk; children and young people, in particular, are at risk from sexual predators.
- You shouldn't trust who you meet; people aren't who (or even where) they say they are.

Digital identity, challenges and opportunities

B. Conditions that Increase Identity Fluidity: Platform anonymity or pseudonymity, Use of avatars or role-playing (e.g., gaming), Limited connection to real-world social networks, Weak audience expectations

C. Conditions that Reinforce Anchored Identity: Use of real name profiles (e.g., email), School-based or workplace communication, Cultural or religious disclosures
Family and peer network participation

3. Identity as Narrative, Performance, and Practice

Identity is an ongoing narrative of the self, continually produced through social interaction. Rather than being fixed or essential, identity is something individuals do, not something they simply possess. Merchant extends this perspective by showing that digital environments intensify the performative nature of identity, requiring users to actively present themselves through text, images, profiles, genre conventions, and platform affordances.

Key Sociological Assumptions

- # Identity is multiple rather than singular — individuals hold several selves simultaneously.

- # Audience matters — online identity-making is shaped by imagined readers.

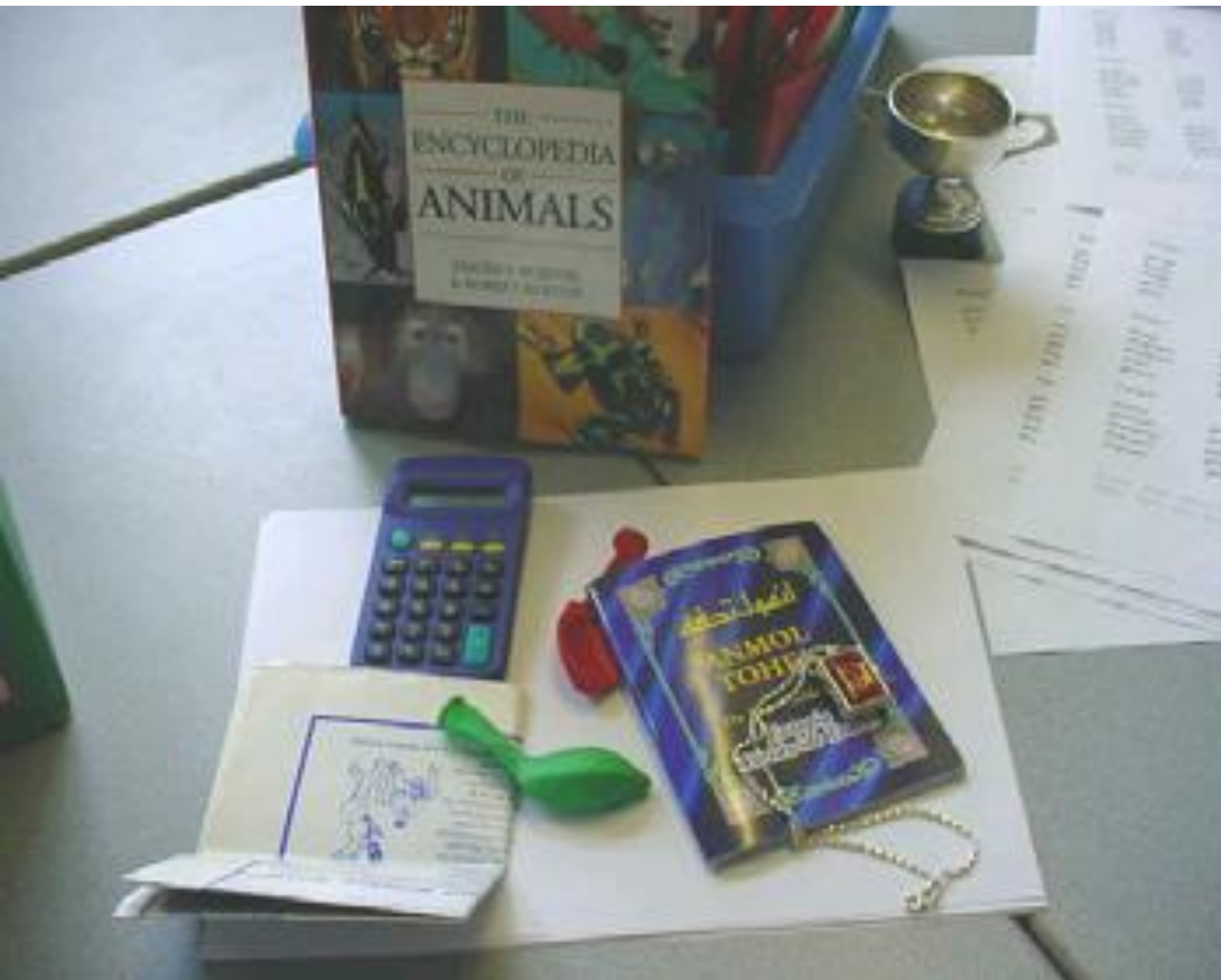
- # Context matters — different platforms encourage different identity displays.

- # Agency + constraint — users choose what to show, but platform affordances and social norms limit possibilities.

- VIdentity is relational — created through interactions and responses from others.

4. Anchored and Transient Identities

Anchored Identities	Transient Identities
Stable, long-term	Fluid, flexible, short-term
Rooted in socio-cultural structures	Rooted in interests, tastes, and media
Harder to modify	Easily revised or updated
Examples: gender, religion, ethnicity, nationality	Examples: fandoms, hobbies, online personas
Influenced by history + institutions	Influenced by cultural trends + peer networks



Example:

Out of the choices available, Nazar has decided to make an overt identity statement, highlighting a significant part of his real-world identity. Although the photograph includes some items of personal significance (such as the balloons and the calculator), one is struck by the way that the chain has been laid across the brochure, allowing for associations to be made between religion and ethnicity.

The accompanying message, of course, points to this, making explicit reference to its religious significance, something which would be difficult to establish simply by studying the image on its own. In a subsequent message, Nazar adds to this depiction of his real-world identities: My hobby is football and bike riding. My best friend is Subhaan. I was born in Pakistan. I like Pakistan more than England.

5. Why Online Platforms Intensify Identity Work

- Absence of physical signs → users must construct identity through symbols.
- Dispersed audiences → communication must address known and unknown others.
- Possibility of anonymity or pseudonymity → encourages experimentation.
- Platform conventions → blogs, gaming spaces, emails, and messaging each allow different identity scripts

6. Levels of Identity Performance Online

Level-1: Surface-Level Performance: Username, Profile picture, Bio, tagline, status update.

Level-2: Interaction-Level Performance: Language style, Posting frequency, Topics of conversation.

Level-3: Deep-Level Performance: Values, beliefs, affiliations, Long-term patterns of media consumption, Forms of network participation

7. Social network and Their Implications for Identity

Forms of Social Network	Characteristics	Impact on Identity
Close-knit communities	Face-to-face, place-based	Identity shaped by location + tradition
Glocalized networks	Local + global communication	Identity shaped by hybrid cultural flows
Networked individualism	Person-centered, mobile, disseminated	Identity becomes personalized, customizable, multi-sited

Digital communication fits most strongly within *networked individualism*, where individuals curate different identity threads across diverse platforms (blogs, games, messengers, forums).

8. Remarks

Identity in online communication remains highly relevant in an era increasingly shaped by social media, gaming platforms, virtual classrooms, and networked communities. Based on anchored and transient identities, computer communication provides a powerful conceptual tool for understanding how individuals curate multiple layers of self-presentation across digital contexts. While online identity is shaped by evolving social structures—from close-knit groups to glocalized networks and finally to networked individualism. Ultimately, digital communication does not erase traditional markers of identity, nor does it fully liberate individuals from social constraints. Instead, it creates complex environments where identity is continuously authored, negotiated, and contested within socio-technical networks. Question is how identities are performed across offline and online networks, how individuals manage multiple audiences, and how digital environments shape the ongoing narrative of the self.